

GEOG 281A

A Mock Cartographic Competition

We have a gallery of maps made by students that include reference maps, vector maps, raster maps, story maps, thematic maps, monochrome maps, ...

Imagine this is a map design competition and you are one of the judges. Prepare to evaluate the maps

Dr. Peter Kedron



ACTIVITY

Purpose: To set an individually based baseline judgement of the quality of the static and interactive maps in the competition

Task:

- Place a sticky note on the two maps that you believe deserve to win the cartography competition.
- On the sticky note, identify the component of the map that made you feel it deserved to win the best map award

SELECTED PRINCIPLES OF SCIENTIFIC CARTOGRAPHY

INTENTION	Everything on a map, and everything off a map, reflects a conscious decision
ARTICULATION	A mapmaker must be able to explain the reason(s) for every decision
AESTETIC TRAP	“I just liked it” is not a reason

REPRESENTATION

REPRESENTATION

What are some of the alternative perspectives about the **G**eographic in GIScience?

ACTIVITY

Purpose: To apply your knowledge of cartographic elements in an analysis of the representational schemes used in these maps.

Task:

For both the static and dynamic map you are assigned prepare a response to the following questions

- What cartographic elements represent information in these maps?
- Has the author of the maps engaged with some fundamental GIScience concepts from our class, or your prior GIScience courses?

BREAK

INFERENCE

INFERENCE

Maps are also systems through which users make and present inferences and generate knowledge

Functionalist Perspective of Scientific Cartography

Elements of Map Inference

- Scale
- Projection
- Symbolization

STUDENT PERSPECTIVE

To what extent does the push towards simplified and non-interactive map design risk producing overconfident or misleading interpretations of spatial patterns, especially for scale dependent and statistically contingent phenomena? How should we reconcile the competing demands of usability, generalization and statistical validity?

ACTIVITY

Purpose: To evaluate the inferential schemes of the maps

Task:

Building on the elements just discussed,

- Place a sticky note that describes one element of the scheme that works well about the inferential scheme.
- Place a note that identifies one element that does not work well.

Consider

- How the design choice share interpretation
- Effectiveness in communicating information to the audience
- The presence of mistakes that affect your understanding

BREAK

JUSTIFICATION

PROMPT

Are you happy with your original selection of the winning maps? If you've changed your mind, move your original sticky and tell us why.

PROMPT

What kinds of bias may have influenced the decision of the judges? Unlike GIS workflows (maybe), cartography allows for more flexibility and interpretation, even with professional standards.

STUDENT PERSPECTIVE

While a good map never tells a complete story, it does tell a digestible story. What then is our role as GIScientists? Is our goal to incorporate more detail in maps and in the hopes of using GIS to uncover and represent truer depictions of the world? Or are we developing systems and methods to make it easier to obscure rich detail in favor of simpler generalizations?

ACTIVITY

Purpose: To determine or consider when a map is done

Task:

How do you know when a map is done? Pick one of the maps.

- Do you think the map is finished?
- If you had to make a similar map, what would be your approach?

Examine

- Make a list of questions the map needs to answer.
- Rank the questions in order of importance
- Distinguish **must** from **might/should**
- Focus on the spatial concepts or relationships your reader needs to understand. Does everything in your plan serve that purpose?

STUDENT PERSPECTIVE

How important are maps to GIS research? How much should a “good” or visually effective map matter in GIS research?